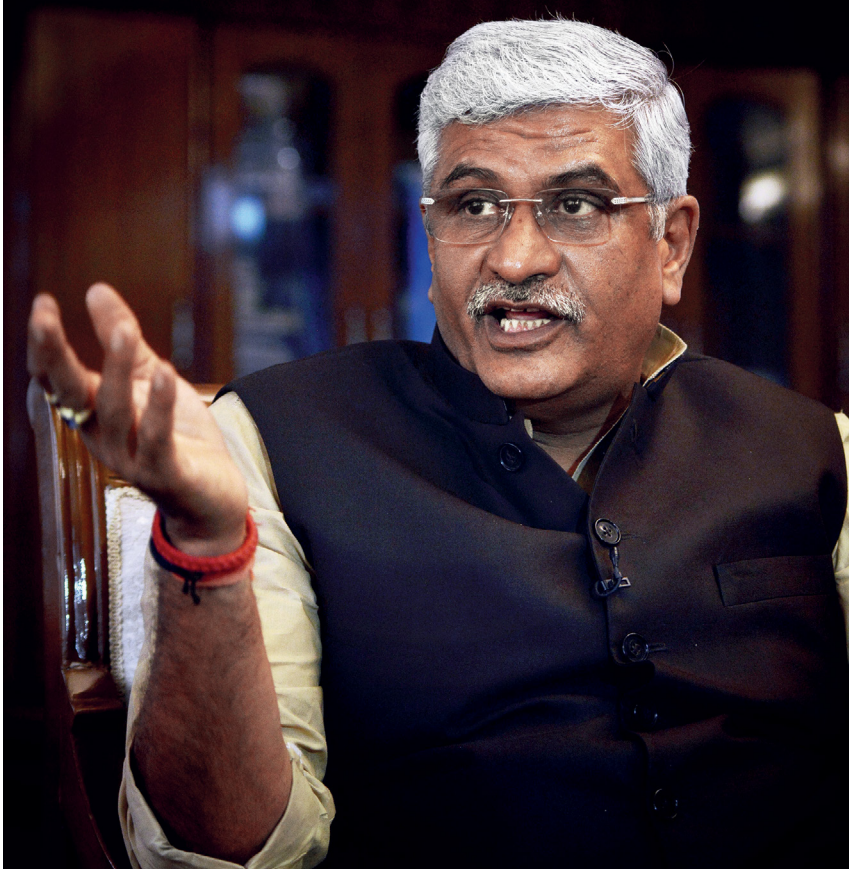




CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

GEHLOT'S CHANGING TARGETS

- In the 1980s and '90s, Ashok Gehlot's target used to be Janata Dal and later BJP CM Bhairon Singh Shekhawat
- During two terms of BJP CM Vasundhara Raje, Gehlot made several harsh comments against her, who retaliated with anti-corruption steps against his aides
- In 2020, Gehlot described rebel Congress leader Sachin Pilot as *nikamma* (worthless) and *nakara* (idle), when facing an attempt by his former deputy to topple his government
- In Shekhawat, Gehlot now has a new bête noire. Shekhawat did defeat his son in 2019, but lost the alleged bid to undo Gehlot in 2020. Who will win the current bout?

should have no objection to this surplus water being used," says Gehlot. Confined to 1,700 MCM, the ERCP, he has said, will remain a drinking water project. Rajasthan also reminds the Centre that even bearing the 40 per cent cost is a burden for a resource-deficit state like it.

Much of the blame for the ERCP not taking off is laid at Shekhawat's door, for his supposed inaction. The Union minister says he is working to include the ERCP into the river linking project, as was originally conceived, so that it gets 90 per cent central funding. "Gehlot is more into playing politics rather than sitting with us to see how ERCP gets through. We cannot twist norms...for such projects," he says.

As the concerned minister, Shekhawat is also frustrated at Rajasthan's slow progress in executing PM Modi's flagship JJM scheme, which aims to provide tapped drinking water to every rural household. Rajasthan ranks a lowly 29th amongst all states and UTs—only 25 per cent of its households have tapped water and it has withdrawn only Rs 2,345 crore of the Centre's Rs 10,181 crore allocation for 2021-22 so far. Rajasthan too has tied up its compliance with the JJM to the ERCP, saying that as a water deficit state, it will be able to provide tap water only if the Centre extends help with the canal project. "Shekhawat must realise that we do not have that much water to provide connections for all households," Gehlot has said.

However, the well-publicised JJM is popular, and the ungainly scrimmage between Gehlot and Shekhawat hasn't gone down well. Gehlot's rivals within the Congress criticise the slow rollout of the JJM, questioning his choice of IAS officers entrusted with executing it. For all his defiance, Gehlot has had to make changes in the PHED and irrigation departments and re-allocate resources to them.

Gehlot has now written to PM Modi, requesting a revision of the deadline for JJM to 2026 from 2024 for Rajasthan, citing a wide range of reasons for the delay—from the 2020 Covid lockdown to spiralling prices due to the war in Ukraine.

On the other hand, Shekhawat's rivals in Rajasthan question his allegiance to his home state and insist he cannot escape responsibility by merely accusing Gehlot.

"He unnecessarily made ERCP a big issue at the conference. Now, if the Centre clears it, Gehlot will get credit and if it does not, he has threatened to make it an election issue...about the Centre's discrimination," says a top Rajput leader of the BJP. ■